

THE PURSUIT OF HAPPYNESS

TEXT: [Proverbs 15:13](#) (NKJV) *“A merry heart makes a cheerful countenance, But by sorrow of the heart the spirit is broken.”*

[Proverbs 17:22](#) (NKJV) *“A merry heart does good, like medicine, But a broken spirit dries the bones.”*

[Nehemiah 8:10](#) (NKJV) *“Then he said to them, “Go your way, eat the fat, drink the sweet, and send portions to those for whom nothing is prepared; for this day is holy to our LORD. Do not sorrow, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.”*

[Galatians 5:22](#) (NKJV) *“But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23 gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law.”*

INTRO: In a recent movie, “**The Pursuit of Happiness**,” Will Smith plays the part of Chris Gardner, a struggling single father in the 1980’s San Francisco. Throughout the movie Smith looks haggard and weary; his voice trembles from time to time as he teeters on the verge of a break-down but manages to hold it together for his son’s sake.

The real-life Chris Gardner, on whose story the film is based, overcame poverty and homelessness to become a successful stockbroker. The film begins with Chris’ wife, Linda on the verge of leaving him and their 5-year-old son, Christopher. Christopher is Will Smith’s real life son. Linda eventually follows through on her threat to leave the family. Chris a not-too-successful

salesman of medical instruments, eventually talks his way into a stockbroker internship at Dean Witter by being able to quickly work a Rubik's Cube (USE THE VIDEO CLIP OF SMITH WORKING THE RUBIK'S CUBE). Much like many opportunities in life, Smith's opportunity at Dean Witter turns out to be an unpaid internship.

Some people have such a dismal outlook on life they often say things like:

- *“The light at the end of the tunnel will likely be an oncoming train...”*
- *“If it was raining soup, I would be outside with a fork and a knife...”*
- *“Every time I make my mark somebody paints the wall...”*

Determined to climb the ladder and make a better life for Christopher, he accepts the internship, and the father/son duo move from apartment to motel room to homeless shelter, with a few nights in a men's room in a BART station along the way.

Throughout the movie, Chris is haunted by a mural outside his son's day-care center, which includes the Declaration of Independence's phrase about man's *“Inalienable right to life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness.”* The word happiness is misspelled on the mural as **“H-A-P-P-Y-N-E-S-S,”** which annoys him. (I know that throughout this series the word happiness is misspelled... I was certainly never a spelling bee champion, but I do know happiness is spelled with an I

rather than a Y – I also have spell check on my computer!!!)

Even though this father finds himself down-on-his-luck he wants his son to learn things correctly. The phrase “[The pursuit of happyness](#)” serves as a challenge to Chris throughout this movie.

The heart of the film is the bond between Chris and Christopher and in Chris' realistically depicted downhill trajectory; poverty and destitution is as close as a missed sale of the medical equipment which was his livelihood.

Ultimately, the real Chris Gardner emerges as an inspirational American success story making millions as a stock broker. The real storyline here is that riches and human relationships are capable of providing true happyness.

Those of us who are Christ followers are aware that it takes more than human relationships and riches to make us truly happy; [a personal, intimate relationship with Jesus is required to obtain true happyness.](#)
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

If you could be granted one wish for yourself and your family, what would you ask for? I'm sure that at the top of most lists we'd find a common answer; happyness. Solomon asked for wisdom because he knew it would influence all of his life's decisions.

In studies done asking people that very question, happyness was the overwhelming response which

shouldn't surprise us. The pursuit of happiness has been an American preoccupation since the penning of the Declaration of Independence well over 200 years ago. Because of those immortal words of Thomas Jefferson about our “*Right to life, liberty and pursuit of happiness*”, we Americans see happiness not only as a desire, but also as being guaranteed by the Constitution. The truth is; **no one but Jesus can guarantee happiness.**

We want our lives to be deeply satisfying and content. We want to experience that comforting feeling of well being; **that sense of stability which enables us to:**

- Weather yesterday's storm...
- Outlast today's moment of elation...
- Endure tomorrow's disappointment...

Quite honestly, it just feels a whole lot better being happy than sad! **Happy people are more...**

- Loving...
- Trusting...
- Forgiving...
- Decisive...
- Creative...
- Sociable...
- Energetic...

...Than unhappy people.

Benjamin Franklin was speaking to a large group of people about the beauty and power of the Constitution. A heckler in the crowd interrupted him and said, “*Sir, them words don’t mean nothin’ at all. Where’s all that*

happyness you say the constitution guarantees us? To which Franklin replied, "My friend, the Constitution only guarantees the American people the right to pursue happyness. You have to catch it for yourself."

Charles Swindoll states, "I know of no greater need today than the need for joy; unexplainable contagious joy; outrageous joy. When that kind of joy comes aboard our ship of life, it brings good things with it like enthusiasm for life; determination to hang in there; and a strong desire to be an encouragement to others. Such qualities make our voyage bearable when we hit the open seas and encounter high waves of hardship that tend to demoralize and paralyze. There is nothing better than a joyful attitude when we face the challenges life throws at us"

William Jones, the great philosopher and psychologist once said *"How to gain, how to keep, and how to recover happyness is in fact for most people at all times the secret nature of all they do."*

It is true that almost everything we do in life is in the pursuit of happyness:

- We work hard to be happy...
- We look for stable relationships to be happy...
- We spend money to be happy...
- We seek out therapy to be happy...
- We vote out certain politicians to be happy
- We vote in certain politicians to be happy...

Our lives are literally lived around the pursuit of happyness.

The Word of God has much to say on this subject, in fact, in the Old Testament alone, there are 27 different words for joy. This shows the importance of having joy throughout our life. **We are told that joy:**

- Is to be sought...
- Comes as a result of Salvation...
- Can be attained in our human relationships...
- Comes as a result of a fruit of the spirit filled life...

I. HAPPYNESS DEFINED...

Galatians 5:22 (NKJV) ***“But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law.”*** The topic being discussed here is the joy of the Lord. **The word joy comes from the Greek word Chara (car-a) which means:**

- Inner gladness...
- Deep seated pleasure...

Joy as it is used here is a depth of assurance and confidence that ignites a cheerful, rejoicing heart. A cheerful heart leads to cheerful, rejoicing behavior!

This kind of life and behavior brings with it health and completeness in life. **Proverbs 15:13 (NKJV) “A merry heart makes a cheerful countenance, But by sorrow of the heart the spirit is broken.”**

Happyiness is revealed:

- **In our words...** If we are happy we will speak happy words...
- **In our conduct...** If we are happy we will do happy deeds...
- **In our lifestyle...** If we are happy it will manifest itself in every area of our life...
- **In our countenance...** If we are happy we should notify our face...

Happyness is not something we stumble upon by accident; it is something we should pursue with every fiber of our beings. **Happyness cannot be:**

- Bought...
- Sold...
- Traded...

Happyness can only come from the Lord and must be acquired through a personal, intimate relationship with Him. **Every person has a God shaped hole in their spiritual make-up and this hole can only be filled by Jesus.**

Proverbs 17:22 (NKJV) “A merry heart does good, like medicine, But a broken spirit dries the bones.”

Happyness is capable of causing our health to be restored. **A broken spirit manifests itself through broken health and many other maladies:**

- Grief...
- Hatred...
- Malice...
- Anxiety...
- Bad tempers...

- Continual worry...
- Negative thinking...

These things do not promote happiness they promote a broken spirit which brings with it an array of health and relational issues. Money can buy medicine but not health. Money can buy momentary joy but not happiness. (Shop until you drop... A woman's place is in the mall... Ecclesiastes - The children gather the wood, the fathers kindle the fire, the women knead (need) their dough...)

It is a scientific fact that happy people are healthier than unhappy people. Being happy is simply more fun than being unhappy. Almost everything we do is done with the hope of experiencing happiness.

Happiness brings with it strength. When the people in Nehemiah's day finished the task of rebuilding the walls and gates of Jerusalem, the people discovered that the strength to do such a thing began with a little word called joy. [Nehemiah 8:10](#) (NKJV) ***"Then he said to them, 'Go your way, eat the fat, drink the sweet, and send portions to those for whom nothing is prepared; for this day is holy to our LORD. Do not sorrow, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.'"***

In a very real sense the pursuit of happiness is the pursuit of the strength of the Lord. [The joy of the Lord is in the truest sense of the word:](#)

- Spiritual strength...
- Physical strength...
- Relational strength...

Happyness is a state of mind and we are entitled to it as Christians. The pursuit of happyness is well worth the effort.

II. HAPPYNESS THE WORLD'S WAY...

It must be pointed out; there is a vast difference between the joy of the Lord and the joy of the world. The happyness of the world is driven by an excitement brought on by an emotional high. The joy of the world is always followed by:

- A nagging sense of incompleteness...
- A feeling that something is lacking...
- A feeling that there is missing ingredients...
- A feeling that something has been left unfulfilled...
- A feeling that a piece of the puzzle has been misplaced...

The happyness which the world offers lack's the ability to deliver a feeling of completion. Somehow there is not a complete sense of assurance, confidence or satisfaction. The most complete sense of joy the world can offer leaves one feeling empty on the inside.

The joy the world offers leaves behind it, a constant awareness that something can, and probably will go wrong. With this world's happyness we are constantly aware that circumstances can change or some situation can arise and disturb our happyness. The joy of the world is temporary, at its best. The things which affect the joy of the world are exhaustive, but some of the

most common interruptions to the peace which the world offers are:

- Sickness...
- The death of a loved one...
- A sudden financial reversal...
- The loss of secure employment...
- The onslaught of family problems...

If a person is living on the strength of the happiness this world offers, when these things develop, their happiness is short lived. Living by this world's system can cause a person's life to emulate a roller-coaster, experiencing exhilarating highs one day and self-defeating lows the next. A person living on this emotional plane can jump the moon with a single bound today, and tomorrow they can stand up-right and walk under a snake's belly.

Who would want to live on such an emotional see-saw? Even if this joy were consistent it is incomplete. It can never fulfill the individual; as a result, the world is in constant need of things and accomplishments to keep their happiness going.

III. HAPPINESS GOD'S WAY...

I would like to now focus on the joy available to the believer. Some very important facts about the joy of the lord are:

- This joy is divine...
- This joy is given by God...
- This joy can only be acquired by true believers...

- This joy does not depend on circumstances as its source...

The joy of the Lord has nothing to do with earthly or material things; it never rides on cheap triumphs; its source is deep seated peace, which flows out of a life lived according to the path which the Spirit has chosen. [Romans 14:17](#) (NKJV) ***“For the kingdom of God is not eating and drinking, but righteousness and peace and joy in the Holy Spirit.” 1***

[Thessalonians 1:6](#) (NKJV) ***“And you became followers of us and of the Lord, having received the word in much affliction, with joy of the Holy Spirit.”***
(My Dad, “You had better wipe that grin off your face... ”)

In Acts 13, Paul and Barnabas are preaching at Antioch and they make the bold assertion that the Jew’s rejected the Gospel, and therefore the Gentiles would have opportunity to receive it! Notice what the Scripture say’s happened as a result of this very enlightening information. [Acts 13:50-52](#) (NKJV) ***“But the Jews stirred up the devout and prominent women and the chief men of the city, raised up persecution against Paul and Barnabas, and expelled them from their region. 51 But they shook off the dust from their feet against them, and came to Iconium. 52 And the disciples were filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit.”***

I suppose some believers would question whether or not it is God’s will for every true believer to possess happiness. I believe [the Scripture teaches that all believers could and should not only pursue but possess](#)

happyness. John 15:11 (NKJV) ***“These things I have spoken to you, that My joy may remain in you, and that your joy may be full.”***

IV. ASSIMILATING HAPPYNESS INTO THE LIFE OF THE BELIEVER...

The joy of the Lord is not dependent on the circumstances of the life of the believer; it is a joy which transcends circumstances and can endure in good times as well as difficult times.

The happyness of the world depends upon certain events coming to pass in ones life, but the joy which God imparts to the believer overrides all things, even matters of life and death. Psalms 5:11-12 (NKJV)

“But let all those rejoice who put their trust in You; Let them ever shout for joy, because You defend them; Let those also who love Your name Be joyful in You. 12 For You, O Lord, will bless the righteous; With favor You will surround him as with a shield.”

2 Corinthians 7:4 (NKJV) ***“Great is my boldness of speech toward you, great is my boasting on your behalf. I am filled with comfort. I am exceedingly joyful in all our tribulation.”***

The reason the happyness which God imparts is able to rise above the circumstances is because it has as its seed, faith. Romans 15:13 (NKJV) ***“Great is my boldness of speech toward you, great is my boasting on your behalf. I am filled with comfort. I am exceedingly joyful in all our tribulation.”*** Philippians 1:25 (NKJV) ***“And being confident of this, I know***

that I shall remain and continue with you all for your progress and joy of faith.”

The believer has a responsibility in the process of the assimilation of happiness into our lives. Two major responsibilities the believer faces:

- Controlling our thought life... Philippians 4:8 (KJV) *“Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy--meditate on these things.”* It is the responsibility of each believer to control our own thought life. God is not going to do it for us it is our responsibility to set a guard at the door of our mind! My mother used to say, *“You can’t keep a bird from flying over your head, but you can keep him from building a nest in your hair!”*
- Guarding the words of our lips... Proverbs 18:21 (NKJV) *“Death and life are in the power of the tongue...”*

The future reward of a life filled with happiness keeps one faithful. Acts 20:24 (NKJV) *“But none of these things move me; nor do I count my life dear to myself, so that I may finish my race with joy, and the ministry which I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God.”* Hebrews 12:1-2 (NKJV) *“Therefore we also, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which so easily ensnares us, and let us run with endurance the race*

that is set before us, 2 looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.”

CONCLUSION:

Every spirit filled believer should be living a life filled with happiness. This happiness should manifest itself in our life and walk. If we will allow the Holy Spirit He can cause us to live a life of happiness, even in times when things may be less than favorable. This walk of happiness should be a tremendous witness to all who do not have it. Unlike Will Smith, this happiness is not dependent on wealth and human relationships.